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I am an applied microeconomist studying how institutional and market frictions affect labor market outcomes and welfare. These frictions include limited access to infrastructure, policy constraints that affect labor force attachment after childbirth, and weak enforcement of minimum wage regulations. I use administrative and survey microdata combined with policy variation to measure the labor market and welfare effects of these frictions and to understand how easing them changes who can reach higher return options, rather than just how many entrants there are. I combine reduced form causal inference with structural models when needed to interpret mechanisms and to evaluate counterfactual policy impacts.

In my job market paper, I show that the welfare impact of mobility policies depends on which segment of constrained high-return workers becomes marginal, not on the total number of workers who shift sectors. I study the abrupt closure of rural rail stations in southern Côte d'Ivoire following the 2011 post-presidential-election crisis as a setting where a shock to mobility costs lets me trace this composition margin. Using nationally representative microdata and a difference-in-differences design, I document sizable declines in per capita spending and a shift out of nonfarm work into lower return contributing family agriculture in affected areas.

I rationalize these findings using a Roy model of sector choice that links per capita spending to whether workers take nonfarm jobs, which come with mobility costs. I then use marginal treatment effects of nonfarm returns and spatial counterfactuals to evaluate reopening policies. I show that reopening only half of the closed stations can recover almost the full welfare gains of full reopening or produce less than fifty percent of those gains solely depending on where stations are placed. The most efficient half reallocates more than three times as many high return workers as the least efficient half. This shows that the returns to infrastructure depend less on kilometers restored and more on who these investments reduce mobility frictions for. This pattern helps reconcile apparently conflicting evidence in the literature on rural infrastructure and structural change. In Asher and Novosad (2020), rural roads expansion enabled movement out of agriculture, yet living standards changed little. In my setting, rail closures generate a comparable scale of movement into contributing family agriculture but with large losses in living standards. In counterfactuals, I show that who reallocates rather than how many ultimately drives the welfare effect.

Building on my job market paper, I plan to identify spillover components in Roy models when potential outcomes in one sector respond to policy driven changes in the size of the other sector. Heckman and Vytlačil (2005) show that in a Roy model where policy change affects potential outcomes within sectors, the identified marginal treatment effect alone can no longer pin down the total impacts of counterfactual policies. I consider one tractable and empirically common case where policy driven changes in sector size shift potential outcomes. The aggregate spillovers can be identified within the same Roy structure. In my job market paper, I show that these spillovers can be quantitatively important and I only provide informative bounds. The next step is to combine differences-in-differences variation over time with cross sectional instrumental variation that shifts sectoral mobility costs across space to identify these spillovers directly. A direct application of this

general case is to go beyond the informative bound in my job market paper and to directly identify nonfarm to farm spillovers that matter for rural economies. Similar spillover patterns arise in college vs non-college education settings (Moretti, 2004).

In another ongoing joint paper, I study heterogeneity in the motherhood employment penalty among immigrants in Canada using administrative microdata. We show descriptive evidence that women who migrate as adults retain penalty levels similar to those in their origin country, while women who arrive as children converge toward Canadian norms, consistent with cultural and institutional adaptation. We then exploit the introduction of the Quebec Parental Insurance Program and find that expanding paid leave eligibility increases post birth employment for low earning immigrant women from low penalty origins.

In joint work in progress, I also document global patterns of minimum wage non compliance, measured as the share of workers earning below the statutory minimum, using harmonized labor microdata from the World Bank's Global Labor Database (GLD) across more than one hundred countries (World Bank Jobs Group, n.d.). We quantify how the prevalence and incidence of these wage violations vary with income levels and worker characteristics such as gender and rural status and how these patterns correlate with inequality across and within countries. This project will establish a global empirical baseline on the scale and distribution of wage theft and create the empirical foundation needed to evaluate enforcement reforms that tighten compliance.

As a follow up, I plan to study whether Ontario's Working for Workers Five Act (Bill 190, 2024) reduced statutory minimum wage violations. The Act doubled maximum individual fines for Employment Standards Act violations to one hundred thousand dollars. Evidence from groups such as the Workers' Action Centre suggests that wage theft is material in Ontario, which motivates studying whether sanction tightening reduces these frictions in practice (Workers' Action Centre, 2025, Oct. 2025). I will use high frequency Labour Force Survey microdata and compare outcomes in Ontario and Quebec around the policy change in a difference in differences design, focusing on subminimum pay, the depth of underpayment, and distributional effects near the bottom of the wage distribution.

In joint work, I study when judge leniency designs are actually credible for causal inference. In this setting, causal interpretation depends on institutional assignment rules and on identifying assumptions including random assignment, monotonicity, and exclusion. Existing tests do not sharply impose all of these restrictions and can fail to detect violations. We derive sharp testable implications of the judge leniency model and propose a statistical test that uses all model restrictions and all information in the data, delivering substantially higher power relative to existing approaches. I am leading the Stata implementation so that applied researchers can reliably diagnose when the institutional environment actually justifies treating judge leniency as a valid instrument.

Taken together, these projects extend the same core question that motivates my job market paper, which is how frictions determine who can reach higher return opportunities and how that shapes labor market outcomes and welfare.

References

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